Ecosystem Marketplace
A FOREST TRENDS INITIATIVE

MARKET INSIGHTS BRIEF | 2026–Q1

VCM Demand Outlook

January 2026

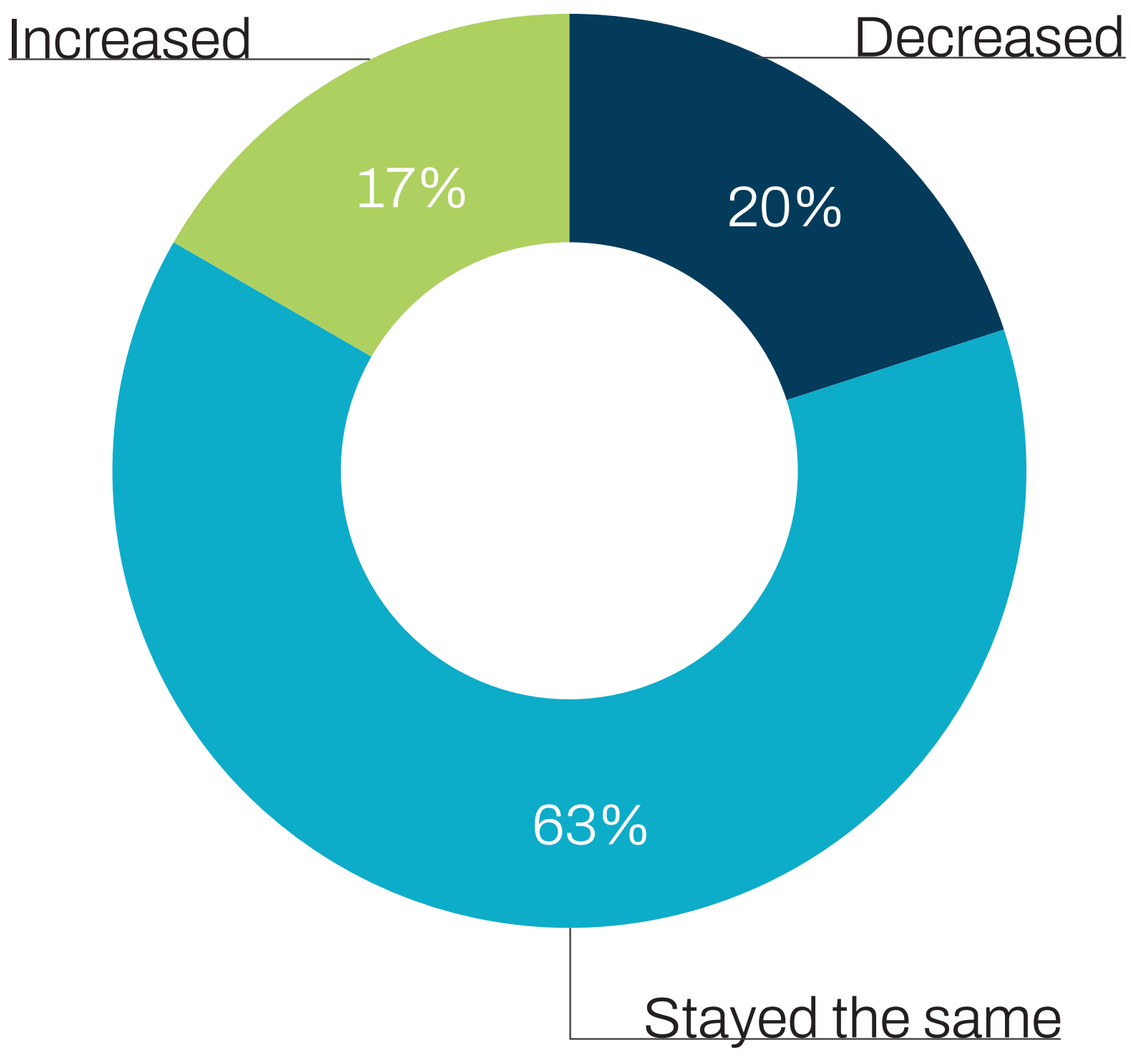
This Market Insights Brief is provided free to the carbon market community as part of Ecosystem Marketplace's (EM) mission to promote transparency and market integrity.

Learn more at www.ecosystemmarketplace.com

What does demand look like for the voluntary carbon market (VCM) in 2026? To get an early read, Ecosystem Marketplace surveyed a sample of carbon project developers in December 2025 about how buyer behavior, pricing trends, and procurement activity compare to where the market was six months ago.

Here’s what we’re hearing from the market.

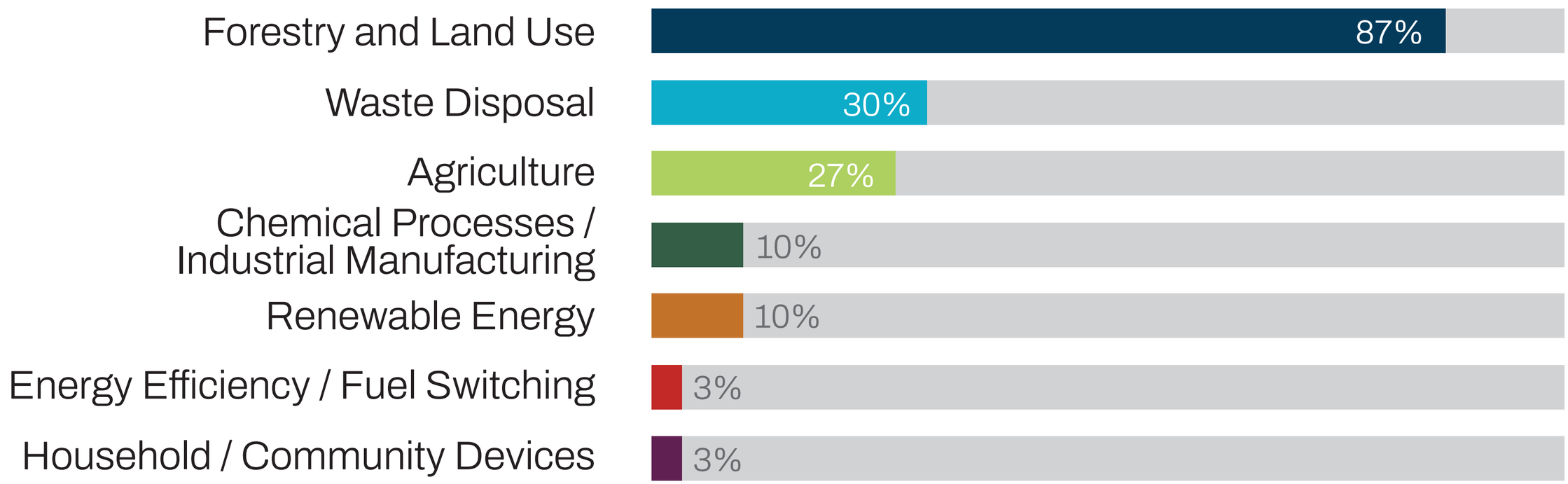
How Does Current Buyer Interest Compare to Six Months Ago?



Market Stabilization

63% of developers report unchanged buyer interest compared to six months ago, while 47% see stable pricing (see page 12). Equal numbers report price increases (27%) versus decreases (27%), suggesting the market has found equilibrium after recent volatility, but expansion remains constrained (see page 12).

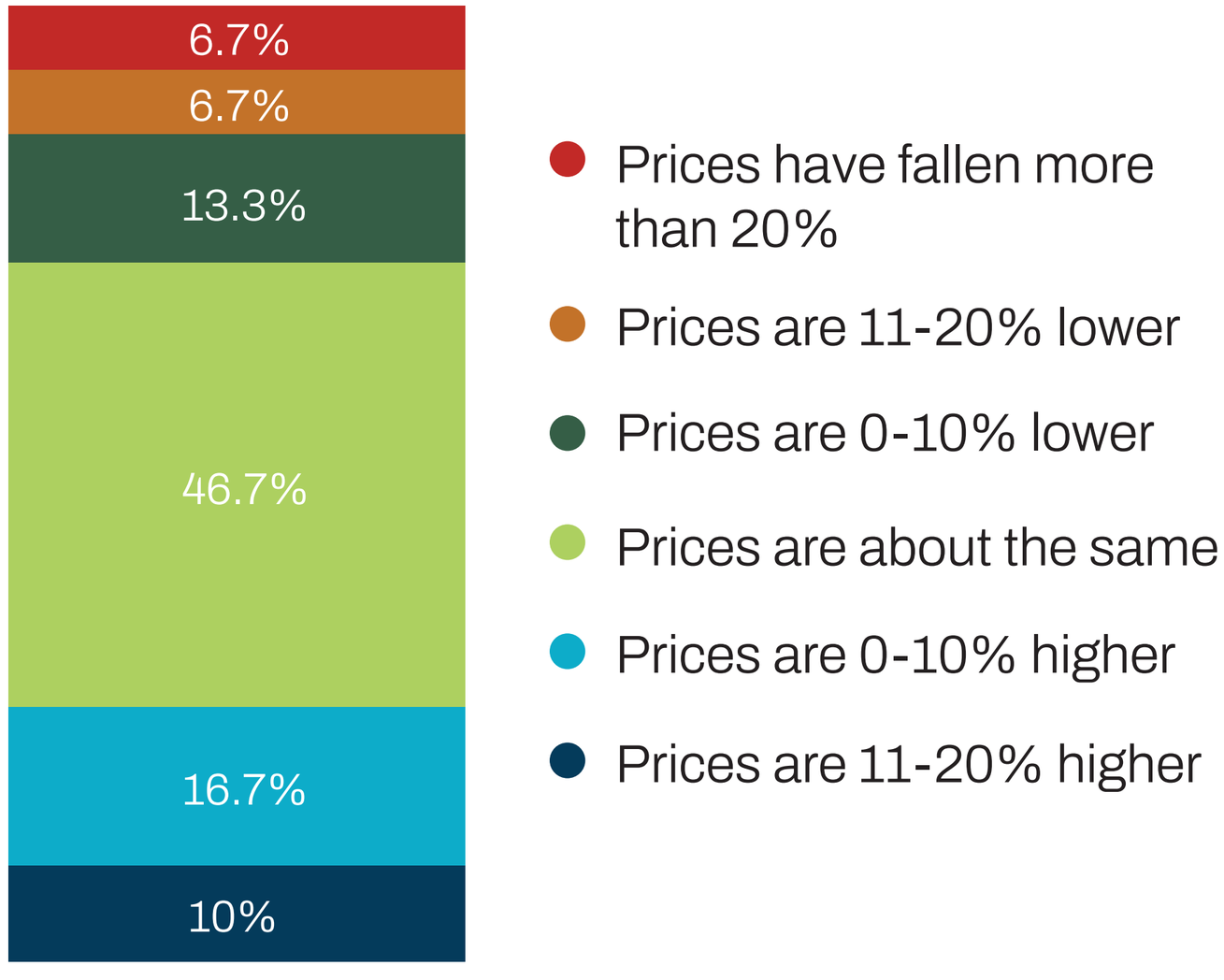
What Project Types are Buyers Asking for?



Nature-based Solutions are in Demand

87% of developers report buyer inquiries for Forestry and Land Use projects—nearly three times higher than any other category. Waste Disposal (30%) and Agriculture (27%) follow at a distance.

What Price Ranges are Buyers Offering Compared to Six Months Ago?

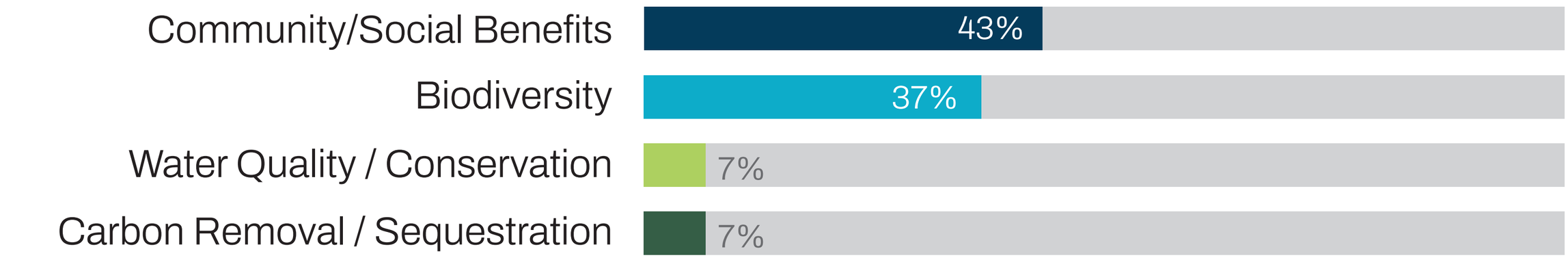


Price Stability Dominates the Market

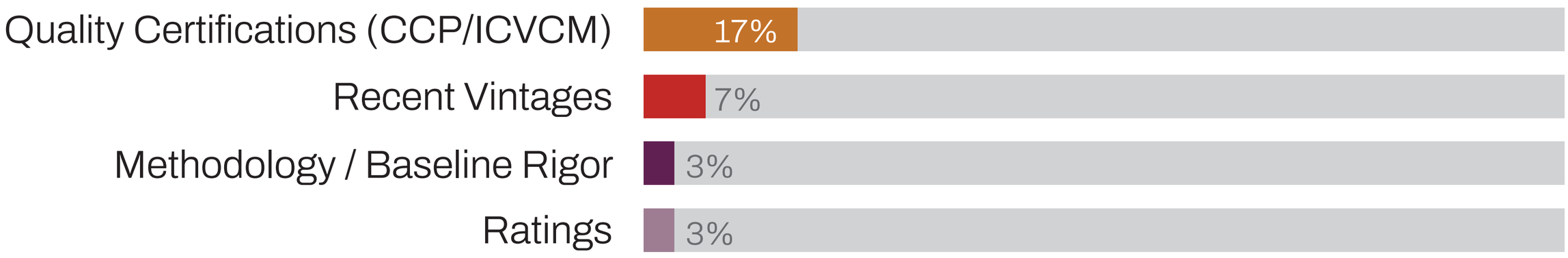
Around half (47%) of developers aren't seeing any big differences in pricing compared to six months ago. Among those seeing movement, just as many developers report price increases than decreases, suggesting modest demand pressure but no clear directional trend.

What Project Attributes are Buyers Prioritizing?

Co-Benefits



Quality/Integrity



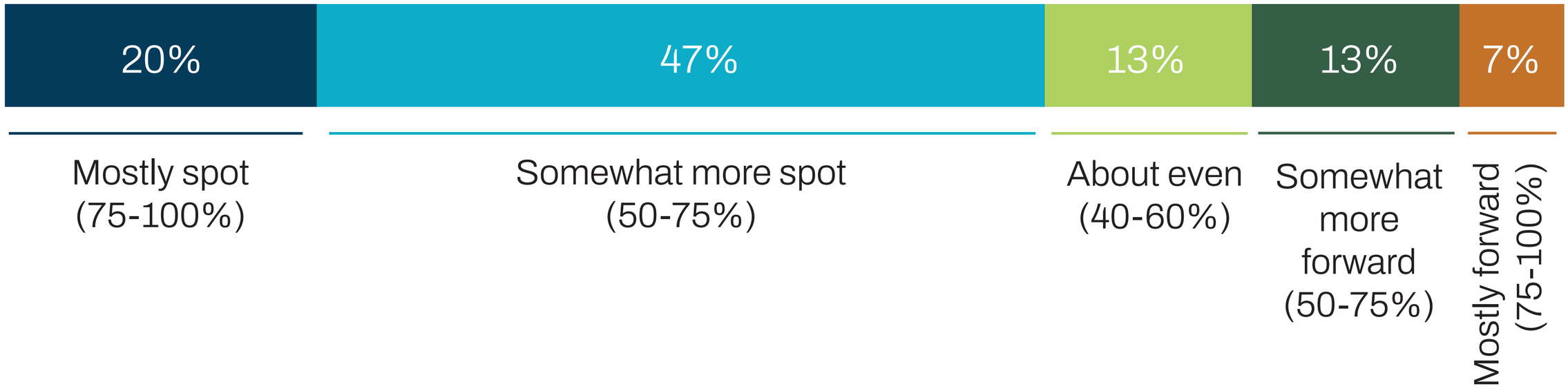
Integrity and Co-benefits Drive Selection

Buyers evaluate projects in terms of both integrity criteria and other attributes like co-benefits. Integrity labels, particularly The Integrity Council for the Voluntary Carbon Market (ICVCM) Core Carbon Principles (17% of developers), increasingly serve as gatekeepers for procurement decisions. Among co-benefits, community and social attributes (43% of developers) and biodiversity (37%) are among the top priorities, with buyers seeking tangible impact beyond carbon reduction.

However, buyer priorities vary—some emphasize robust quantification and quality ratings above co-benefits.

Notably, only 3% of developers report buyers explicitly prioritizing methodology or baseline rigor, which may indicate either that these considerations are assumed/implicit in certification requirements, or that they're being underweighted in procurement decisions.

Spot vs Forward Delivery Inquiries



Spot Market Dominates, Forward Interest Emerging

67% of developers report mostly or somewhat more spot delivery inquiries, indicating buyers prefer de-risked, issued credits over forward commitments. However, 20% see forward-heavy inquiries, suggesting some buyers are building longer-term procurement strategies for 2026 and beyond.

Deal Conversion and Execution

Average conversion rate:

Just **6.1%** of inquiries convert to actual deals. This low conversion rate suggests friction in the purchase pipeline and increasingly selective buyers.

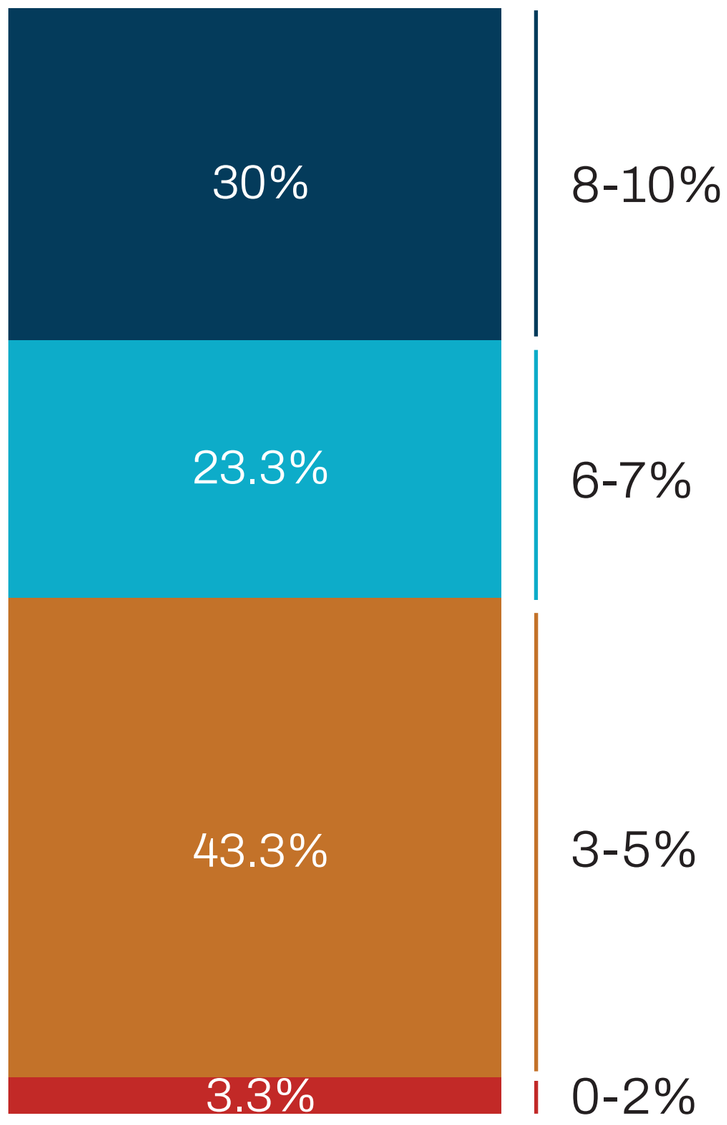
Deal completion rates holding steady:

77% report no change vs six months ago.

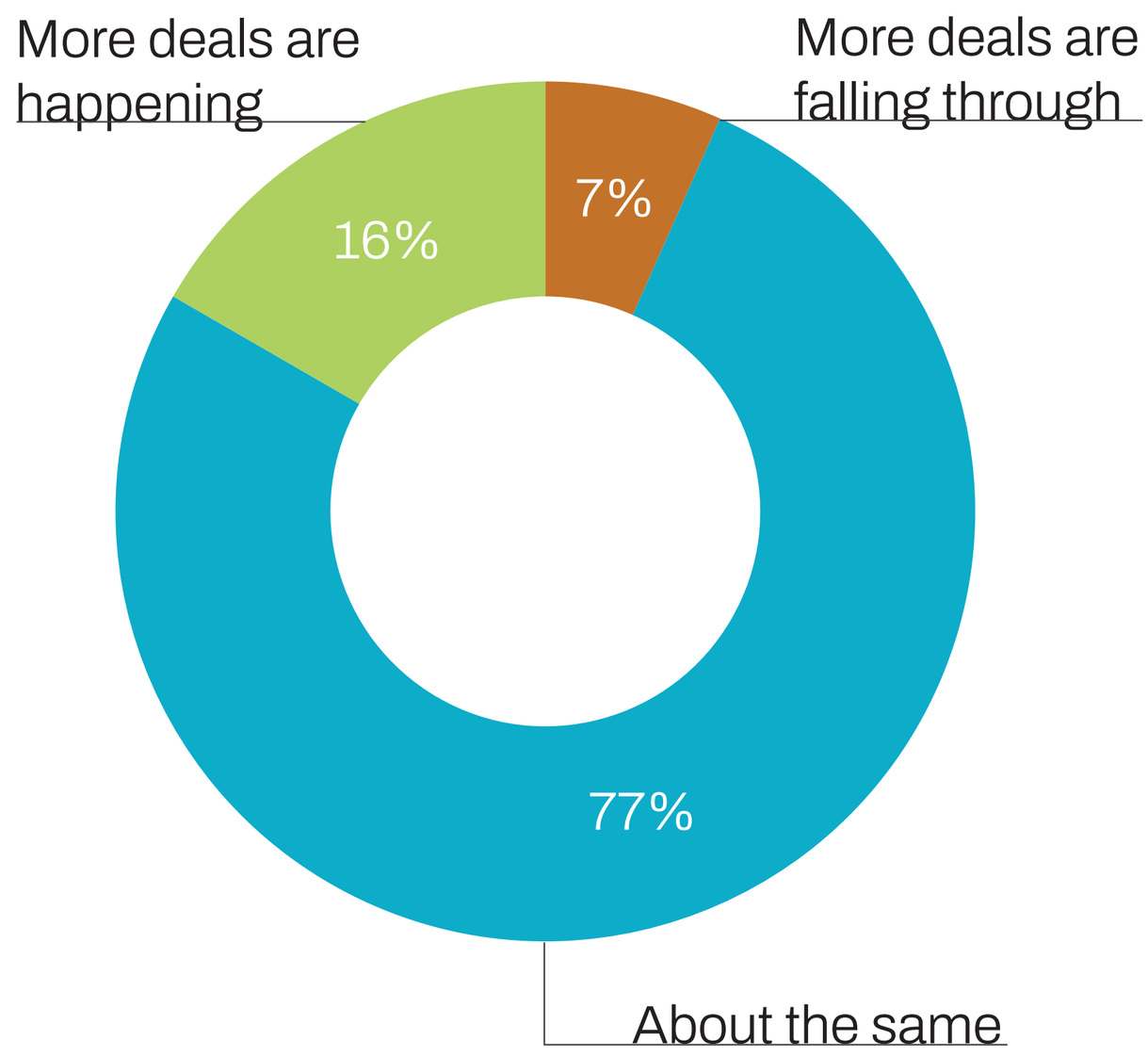
Positive momentum:

17% tell EM they see more deals closing, versus only **7%** experiencing more deals falling through.

Inquiry-to-Deal Conversion Rates



Deal Completion Trends vs Six Months Ago



2026 Outlook

The coming months in 2026 appear on track for market stability and selective recovery. Serious buyers are active and procurement processes are formalizing, but overall market expansion remains limited. The market has stabilized after significant volatility, with prices finding equilibrium and deal execution holding steady. Buyer preferences for quality—well documented by Ecosystem Marketplace in recent analysis—likewise remain constant.

Projects with **strong biodiversity credentials, meaningful community co-benefits, and quality certifications** (particularly ICVCM Core Carbon Principles) will be best positioned to capture available demand. Nature-based solutions, especially Forestry and Land Use projects, will continue to dominate buyer interest.

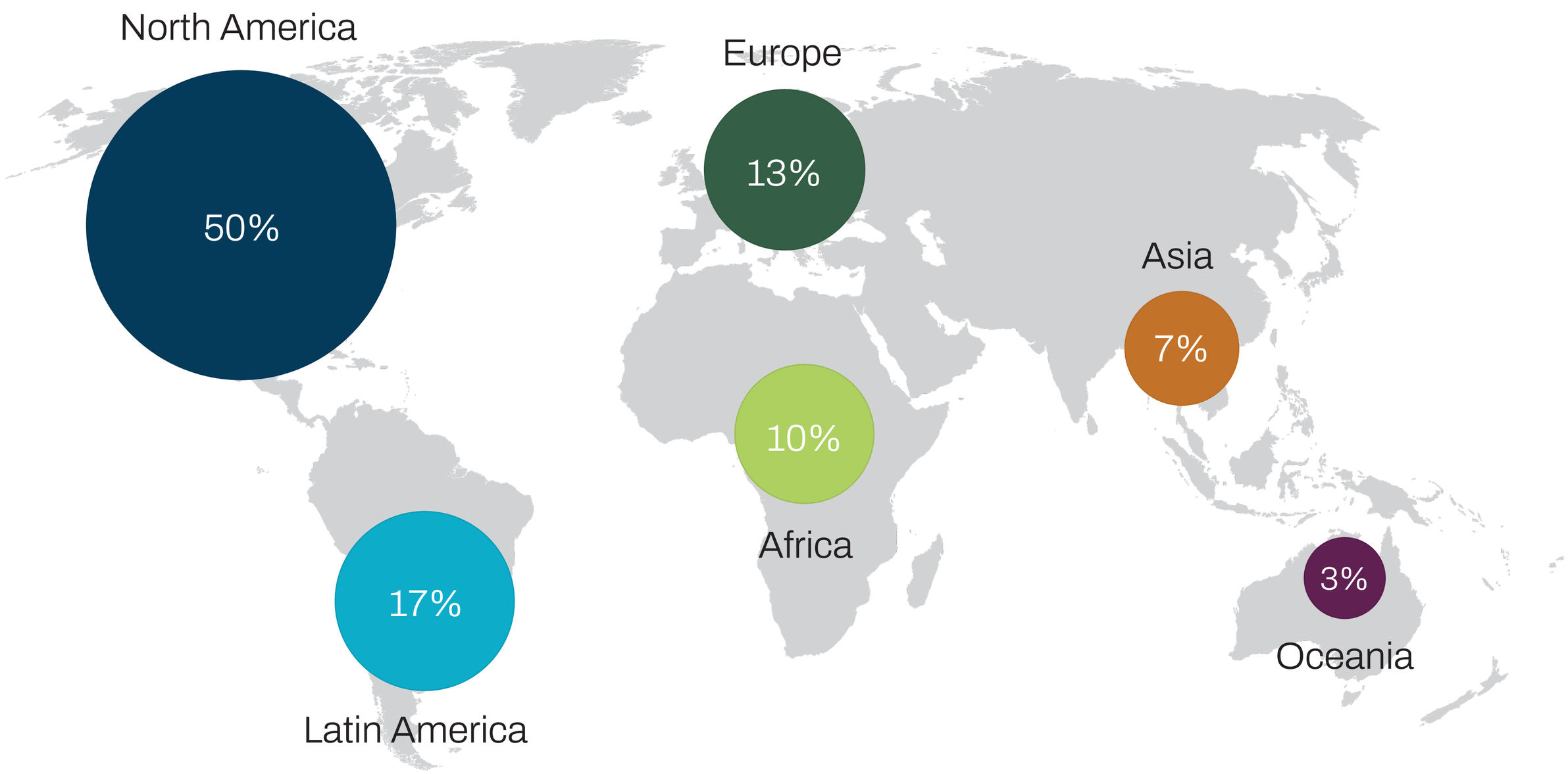
However, the low inquiry-to-deal conversion rate (averaging just 6%) suggests **highly selective buyers, or friction in the purchase pipeline** (whether related to shifting buyer needs, quality concerns, evolving standards, or due diligence)—a topic we'll cover in an upcoming Market Insights Brief.

Methodology and Sample

This Market Insights Brief draws on a survey conducted in December 2025 of 30 respondents: 20 carbon project developers (66%) and 10 brokers/intermediaries (33%). Respondents represent diverse project portfolios: Forestry and Land Use (16 organizations, 53%), brokers/intermediaries working across multiple project types (10 organizations, 33%), Renewable Energy (4 organizations, 13%), Waste Disposal (2 organizations, 7%), and Agriculture (1 organization, 3%). Respondents were asked about buyer inquiry trends, pricing movements, project type preferences, co-benefits and quality criteria, delivery timing (spot vs forward), and deal execution dynamics over the previous six months.

Results provide early demand indicators for 2026 but should not be considered comprehensive given the limited sample size. The findings represent reported experiences from a subset of project developers and may not capture the full diversity of market dynamics across all regions, project types, and buyer segments.

Respondent Geography



About Ecosystem Marketplace

Ecosystem Marketplace (EM), a non-profit initiative of Forest Trends, is a leading global source of information on environmental finance, markets, and payments for ecosystem services. For nearly two decades, EM has operated the world's first and only globally recognized reporting and transparency platform for voluntary carbon market pricing data, news, and insights.

EM's flagship State of the Voluntary Carbon Market reports and analyses on market dynamics—including pricing, transaction volumes, project types, corporate buyers, sellers, and registry data—have become anticipated industry staples relied upon by project developers, buyers, investors, policymakers, and civil society organizations worldwide.

As a non-profit with no commercial stake in carbon markets, EM is committed to delivering credible, independent market intelligence that bridges knowledge gaps and supports informed decision-making. EM believes that transparency is a hallmark of robust markets, and that by providing accessible and trustworthy information, it can contribute to market growth, catalyze new thinking, and support the development of the policies and infrastructure needed for effective climate action.

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